

PREPARING FOR PARENTHOOD?

Gender, Aspirations, and the Reproduction of Labor Market Inequality

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This article explores how anticipations of parenthood differentially affect the career aspirations and choices of women and men who have not (yet) had children. Drawing from in-depth interviews conducted separately with 60 coupled young adults (30 heterosexual couples), I find that women in my sample were disproportionately likely to think and worry about future parenthood in their imagined work paths. Moreover, women were more likely than men to alter or downshift their present-day career goals in anticipation of the changes in preferences and responsibilities that accompany new parenthood. Because men were unlikely to engage in the mental work of anticipating parenthood, they were also free from its emotional and behavioral consequences. In this way, gendered anticipations of parenthood, which begin relatively early in an individual's career path, are likely to play a key role in reproducing patterns of labor market inequality even before the real constraints of parenthood have set in.

Keywords: *gender; work/family; parenthood; motherhood; aspirations*

Over the last several decades, there has been considerable interest among sociologists to explain the role of parenthood in shaping the labor market experiences of mothers and fathers. This is because new parenthood remains a critical juncture in which women's and men's career trajectories often diverge substantially, with women tending to scale back and men tending to ramp up their involvement in paid labor (Cohen and

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Bianchi 1999; Grunow, Schultz, and Blossfeld 2012; LaRossa and LaRossa 1981; Sanchez and Thomson 1997). Labor market involvement is closely linked to the gender gap in pay, which, on average, is also larger among parents (Waldfogel 1998).

Qualitative attempts by sociologists to explain the influence of parenthood expectations and constraints on individual career choice have relied almost exclusively on the accounts of new parents (Cowan and Cowan 1992; Stone 2007; Walzer 1996; Webber and Williams 2008). Yet scholarship that empirically addresses the career choices women and men make during the critical period that precedes parenthood, when many young adults are forming committed partnerships and forging their paths in the workplace, is scant. This article aims to fill this gap by exploring the role of cultural assumptions about gender, parenthood, and family care work in shaping the imagined work paths of middle- and upper-class young adults who are engaged or married but who do not yet have children. Since this is a stage when career and family paths are particularly salient and pliable, it is important to ask how anticipations of parenthood influence the decisions that childless individuals make in the workplace. For example, do future plans to have children differentially affect the career aspirations and choices of women and men?

I draw on data from in-depth interviews with 60 college-educated childless young adults (30 heterosexual couples) living in the San Francisco Bay Area to show how gender shapes the mental, emotional, and behavioral aspects of early career choice. Women in my sample were more likely than men to think about and worry about combining children with their careers. Moreover, women were more likely to ramp down their present-day career aspirations in anticipation of future parenthood and the perceived concomitant changes in preferences and responsibilities that accompany new motherhood. Men in my sample were much less likely to consider future parenthood at all when making career-related goals and decisions; however, when they did, they more often ramped up their career paths in accordance with traditional breadwinner expectations. In the aggregate, these individual-level choices, which occur relatively early in one's career path, are likely to play a key role in reproducing patterns of gender difference in labor patterns as well as the unequal distribution of material and nonpecuniary rewards that ensues from that difference.

THE FORMATION OF CAREER ASPIRATIONS

Survey data consistently show that while the majority of contemporary couples maintain egalitarian labor arrangements before having children,

many tend to shift to more traditional arrangements upon the birth of their first child (Grunow, Schultz, and Blossfeld 2012; LaRossa and LaRossa 1981; Sanchez and Thomson 1997). This finding remains even among gender egalitarians (Grunow, Schultz, and Blossfeld 2012).

In one particularly compelling in-depth study on the topic, Stone (2007) interviewed 54 high-achieving mothers who had “opted out” of the paid labor force. She, as well as others doing research in the field (Hays 1996; Webber and Williams 2008), found that mothers are pulled toward their family lives by the cultural ideology of intensive mothering. Simultaneously, mothers in Stone’s sample describe being pushed out of their careers by unrealistic workplace policies and bosses who made balancing “ideal worker norms” (Williams 2000) with childrearing demands nearly impossible.

While structural forces like these undoubtedly influence the reproduction of labor market inequality that results from new parenthood, it is also possible that some of what drives couples’ decisions at new parenthood begins well in advance of the birth of a child. In other words, couples may make what they deem as rational choices at the time of a child’s birth based on each partner’s relative earnings, occupational satisfaction, and tenure, all of which may be impacted by processes occurring before parenthood. This article takes a step toward building our understanding of these processes by asking whether anticipations of parenthood shape aspirations in gender differentiated ways.

The literature on aspirations shows that gendered career choices begin very early in the life course, well in advance of family formation. Female high school and college students tend to be less likely to enter more lucrative male-typed majors and jobs (Jacobs 1995; Lips 2007; Machung 1989); and the gap between college-educated women and men’s reported likelihood of entering a career in the fields of math or science widens as they age (Lips 2004). College-age women are also less likely to believe they will be in positions of power in the paid labor force (Lips 2000).

Social psychologists have provided some of the best evidence of the causal mechanisms that may be at play, linking self-assessments to aspirations early in the life course. Correll (2004) finds that women tend to assess themselves lower in performance of culturally defined male-typed tasks (e.g., math- and science-oriented tasks) because of the lower status accorded to women in society, making them less likely to enter careers in these fields. Other research on the topic suggests the potential for gender stereotypes and environmental messages to similarly dissuade women from entering male-dominated domains by priming them with ideas about their potential fit in such positions (Cheryan et al. 2009).

It is clear, then, that career aspirations and the social forces that shape them are both gendered and consequential. But what bearing, if any, do family aspirations and expectations have on individuals' work lives? Some social scientific evidence suggests that aspirations for family life, and for a certain work–family structure, in particular, may also play a key role in shaping individual career aspirations. For instance, using in-depth interviews with college students, Machung (1989) found that women's career-related aspirations are curbed early on by a preference for work–family balance and by privileging men's careers over their own.

This finding is contrasted in the literature, however, by those who find that young adults' family expectations have little impact on early labor market aspirations. For instance, Gerson (1985, 20) argues that youth aspirations often diverged from women's later work–family orientations because “early plans can ultimately turn out to be uninviting or even impossible, encouraging or perhaps requiring individual change.” Damaske (2011) interviewed 80 women about their early workforce participation expectations and found that the vast majority of middle- and upper-class women, the group most directly comparable to those in my (and Machung's) study sample, expected to work continuously throughout their adult lives, suggesting that intermittent work in anticipation of child care needs may not affect those with the most access to human capital. Thus, it is unclear whether (and how) family aspirations and expectations are linked to early workplace choices.

One burgeoning area of sociological work that offers insight, however, explores college-age young adults' work–family structure preferences. In a recent study on the work–family structure expectations of unmarried women and men, Gerson (2010) finds that, while the vast majority of young adults report a strong desire for an egalitarian relationship (their “Plan A” work–family structure), many believe it will be an impossibility because of highly rigid, institutionalized work structures. In turn, they form gendered “Plan B” preferences, with men opting for a type of neotraditional family structure and women opting for a self-reliant model. A recent experimental study by Pedulla and Thébaud (2013) largely corroborated Gerson's (2010) qualitative findings.

While these studies offer unique insight into the potential disconnect between young adult work–family ideals and outcomes, their empirical focus remains on single young adults for whom the option of falling back on self-reliance is likely not accompanied by thoughts of separation from a partner to whom they've committed, as it would imply for coupled young adults. Coupled young adults may also have shifted aspirations and

preferences in response to the gendered expectations that accompany marriage (Davis and Greenstein 2009; Risman 1998). Vespa argues that “changes in gender ideology are more likely a consequence, or by-product, of exposure to new social situations and roles that are embedded with gendered expectations” (2009, 365), such as the role of wife-husband or mother-father. Given the implicit link between gender ideology and work–family aspirations, the transition to marriage and its culturally assumed association with parenthood is likely one such social situation that shapes aspirations. Yet the extent and effects of parenthood expectations on childless *coupled* young adults is unclear.

Thus, myriad unanswered questions remain about the complex process of navigating conflicting ideals and interests in the face of constraint as individuals move through the life course, from singlehood toward coupled parenthood. This article takes a step toward filling this gap by asking how, if at all, coupled young adults without children interpret gendered parenthood expectations and work–family conflict at a critical juncture in their labor force trajectory.

METHODS

The data used in this article come from in-depth interviews with 60 childless men and women in 30 heterosexual couples. Because the data are part of a larger data set about new marriage, couples were either married (73 percent) or engaged and cohabiting (27 percent). Much like marriage, engagement is a culturally legitimated way of formalizing a relationship that often carries a strict set of gender expectations. It is also accompanied by larger shifts in how couples think about their relationship and is thus similarly important to the study of gender dynamics in family formation.

Sample members were between the ages of 25 and 34, a period when young adults tend to make key decisions about work and family life. This is also an age range in which individuals are likely to be coupled but not yet parents—the life stage of interest for this particular study. Among those who were married, 95 percent had been married for three years or less. I found no discernable differences in how the processes described in this article operate between married and engaged couples, nor do I find noticeable differences by age. To demonstrate this, I’ve included the marital status and age of each respondent quoted here. Because I was seeking to explain how individuals think about and prepare for parenthood

before actually becoming parents, none of the respondents in my sample had children. Fifty-four were certain they would have children in the near future, while six were considering parenthood, but less definitively.

Participants were recruited through a variety of methods, including Craigslist advertisement, referrals, and snowball sampling and were told that the interviews were about newly married or engaged couples without children. Because I did not want to prime respondents for gender dynamics, I did not mention the word “gender” at any point during the description of the study. I also removed “gender” and “gender inequality” as research interests in publicly available areas that respondents might find when looking into my background/experience before the interview (e.g., on my online CV and on my Academia.edu profile).

Interviews typically occurred in respondents’ homes, but some were also conducted in coffee shops, public libraries, or places of employment. Because I wanted respondents to feel comfortable discussing sensitive topics as well as sources of tension in their relationship, I conducted the interviews separately with each member of the couple.¹ Interviews lasted between 75 minutes and three hours, with the average interview lasting two hours. Interviews were semistructured, containing a set of key questions asked of each respondent, but respondents were probed on topics that emerged organically during the interview as well.² All interviews were digitally recorded and transcribed verbatim.

Table 1 presents descriptive statistics of the analytic sample.³ Family formation patterns tend to codify across class lines, making childless married (or engaged) partnership more likely to occur among young adults with higher socioeconomic status. Though I did not impose income or educational parameters to the study, my sample is no exception to this broader pattern and is populated almost entirely by middle- and upper-class couples.

According to their responses to attitudinal questions taken verbatim from the General Social Survey asked in an online survey, sample members are relatively egalitarian in their gender ideologies (see Table 1), a finding that is perhaps unsurprising given San Francisco’s well-known liberal sociopolitical bent. However, as I will show, what *is* surprising is the vast amount of gendering in their anticipations of parenthood even among this highly egalitarian-minded sample. Thus, I suspect that the gendered processes that I describe in this article would be even more pronounced in a nationally representative sample of childless young adult couples.

I coded each interview transcript in Dedoose software for qualitative and mixed methods research, relying heavily on a grounded theory

TABLE 1: Demographic and Attitudinal Characteristics of Sample Members

<i>Variables</i>	<i>Measures</i>	<i>Percentages and Means</i>
Couple-level		
Relationship status	Married	73%
	Engaged	27%
Couple-level income ^a	Combined income in dollars/year	145,967
Relative earnings	Woman earns 60% or more	20%
	Man earns 60% or more	40%
	Partners each earn between 40% and 60%	40%
Relative education	Woman has more education	33%
	Man has more education	10%
	Partners have same level of education	57%
Individual-level		
Age	Mean age	29
Education	Some college	8%
	Bachelor's degree	52%
	Graduate degree	40%
Income	Individual income in dollars/year	73,818
Race/ethnicity	White	67%
	Black	7%
	Latino/Latina	8%
	Asian	7%
	Other/mixed race	12%
Region of origin	Northeast	15%
	Midwest	12%
	West	70%
	South	3%
% Who disagree with the following ^b	More important for wife to help with husband's career than have one herself	98%
	Men better suited for politics than women	84%
	A preschool child is likely to suffer if mother works	93%
	Better if man is the achiever outside of home	89%

NOTE: Data come from surveys collected before/after the interview. Five sample members had incomplete survey data. I filled in where possible (e.g., race or education), but otherwise, their data are treated as missing here. *N* = 60.

- a. Determined by summing each partner's reported individual income.
- b. I measured responses to four gender attitude questions, which were borrowed verbatim from the General Social Survey. Response categories (strongly agree, agree, disagree, and strongly disagree) were collapsed to create dummy variables of agreement with gender egalitarian attitudes where 1 = gender egalitarian attitudes (i.e., disagreement to the statements listed above).

approach (Glaser 1978; Glaser and Strauss 1967). The coding for the project took place in two distinct stages: open coding and theoretical coding, following the guidelines proposed by Glaser (1978). Open coding served to organize the data; I organized the data for this article under one primary variable or theme (anticipated parenthood) and then included several distinct concepts that fell under that theme (mental burden, emotional experiences, educational shifts, occupational shifts, anticipated labor strategies in parenthood, etc.). I used indicators, or concrete examples in the data, to drive the creation of each of these themes. During the theoretical coding process, I sought to explain the causes, consequences, and contingencies under which the core variable operates within the data (Glaser 1978). The quotes I present here can be viewed as a representation of the salient themes in the data and can be interpreted for their value in explaining process and furthering theories of labor market inequality.

THE ROLE OF GENDER IN PREPARING FOR PARENTHOOD

I argue that one vehicle through which labor inequality is perpetuated is through anticipations of parenthood. I identify three processes through which this cultural mechanism influences coupled women and men without children: (1) mental processes that lead women to be more likely than men to consider parenthood in their imagined career trajectories; (2) emotional processes that cause negative affective experiences for women, but not men, in preparing for the intersection of future parenthood and paid employment; and (3) behavioral processes that lead women and men to differentially adjust their current career goals in anticipation of future parenthood.

The Mental Work of Anticipating Parenthood

Among the individuals that I interviewed, gender played a critical role in determining the mental work associated with anticipating parenthood, particularly as it intersected with respondents' imagined labor trajectories. I use the term *mental work* to describe the active thinking and feeling work that takes place in anticipation of family needs. The concept was first introduced to gender and family scholarship by Walzer (1996) in her discussion of new parenthood, but similar concepts have also been developed in research on household labor (DeVault 1991; Hochschild 1989).

My use of the term, however, varies from Walzer's (1996) in important ways. First, Walzer describes three categories of mental work: worrying, processing information, and managing the division of labor. Given that my study participants are not yet at the stage of researching parenthood or managing child care responsibilities, my use of the term is relegated to the social psychological realm of future parenthood only.

Second, I argue that the mental work evident in my data is the result of internalized expectations about motherhood and fatherhood. Walzer (1996) similarly argues this, but also suggests that interactional dynamics, such as partner pressures or demands, contribute to the gendering of mental work as well, which I do not find. In fact, while respondents in my sample had all discussed their *intent* to have children with their partners, almost none had explicitly discussed future parenthood responsibilities and their alignment with work with their partners. While I don't find support for an interactional story in my data, the research design that I employ, interviewing coupled partners separately, still offers leverage as it allows me to compare *within* couples, using the couple as a loose type of control for household income, anticipated family assistance, and family planning. Where relevant, I unpack this dimension throughout my findings.

Third, Walzer distinguishes between "baby worry," which she describes as "an integral part of taking care of the baby" (1996, 222), and "mother worry," which is the result of mothers' concerns about "how others evaluate them as mothers" (ibid., 223). Given that my respondents are childless, however, I do not refer to this as a specific type of worry, but instead use mental work as a blanket term to refer to all thinking, feeling, and worrying associated with future parenthood.

The gendering of mental work evident in my sample is best illustrated when quantified. After asking respondents to describe their current work situation, and prior to explicitly asking about their considerations of parenthood, I asked each the following question: "Where do you see your work life going in the next five to ten years?" While the topic of children had rarely been discussed at this point in the interview, this question alone elicited a bevy of gendered responses. Indeed, in response to this focal question, approximately 77 percent of women in my sample mentioned parenthood or child care in their description of their imagined work paths without interviewer probing; this is in stark contrast to the 10 percent of men who mentioned it. Men, for the most part, viewed their future careers through an unmuddled career-focused lens while women viewed it through the lens of future motherhood.

For example, Tamar⁴ (age 30, married) had recently begun a public sector job evaluating the effects of environmental programs, which she

enjoyed. When asked about the direction of her work life in the next five to 10 years, she cited uncertainty, saying, "I don't know when we're gonna have kids. We're thinking about it. So I'm not sure how that would work in with the career path and all that." In response to the same question, Cindy (age 32, married) immediately said, "Well, we do wanna have kids soon . . ." before continuing on to describe the various employment paths she was considering, making clear that the idea of motherhood complicated her envisioned work path.

Erin (age 32, engaged) told me that having kids "is kind of like in the back of my mind," as she discussed whether she wanted to stay in her current job or look for something she found more fulfilling. Sandy (age 25, married), who was working as a restaurant manager, anticipated the conflict that motherhood might present to her career when she told me, "I'd love to just stay where I'm at. I feel like I finally found a place where I fit, where it feels right, feels good. And everything's lined up. But I also want to be a mom."

Marcella (age 28, married), an office manager at a law firm, was interviewing candidates for open positions. In response to my focal question, she replied that while she routinely asked potential job candidates the same exact question, "I can't answer it for myself." She continued on, describing the back and forth dialogue she has with herself and her "girl-friends" about the matter: "It's hard for me to, like, keep it in perspective. . . . In five or ten years, maybe I'll just be a mom. Maybe I'll be working part-time. Maybe I'll take maternity leave and return back to work." Like Marcella, many women respondents' discussions of their future labor trajectories were intertwined with ideas about parenthood and uncertainty about how new motherhood might affect their involvement in the paid labor force.

Men's considerations of parenthood were largely absent from their discussions of career aspirations. When I explicitly asked whether theirs or their partners' work lives might change upon new parenthood, their answers seemed to convey that they had not considered the topic, at least not seriously, before. For instance, Donald (age 27, married), a sales manager at an IT firm, replied, "Oh, that's a good question. Um . . . I don't know." Nathan (age 30, married), a computer programmer, offered a similar response: "That's a good question . . . I dunno. I think that's it's hard. It's an interesting question. . . . I don't know if we've put a ton of thought into exactly how that process would work or not." While Nathan implies that he and his partner *together* have not considered the topic, my interview with his partner, Marcella (quoted above), tells a different story.

When asked to comment on how his or his wife's work might change upon parenthood, Caleb (age 32, married) told me he had not thought much about the topic, but instead worried about other aspects of his life in imagining parenthood:

I honestly haven't thought about it that much. I guess the one thing that, like, scares me about having a kid and that I *have* thought about a lot is, like, I have to make sure that I have my own time. That I can go play sports or go and be with friends and it's okay. Like, I have some specified amount of time each week that's my time without the kid, and [my wife] will take care of it. And vice versa, of course. But I worry about that much more than almost anything else. I'd just hate losing my life for the kid.

Others contrasted their personality types with that of their wives, who they frequently dubbed "the planners." For instance, Bobby (age 29, married) told me, "I'm more of a procrastinator. I worry about things as they become more urgent or close to the deadline. So until we have kids, it's not a big concern of mine."

Some women were attuned to the fact that their partners were not giving the idea of parenthood and work-life balance as much consideration as they were. But like their partners, they offered individual-level personality differences as the reason for these differences. For example, when I asked Denise (age 27, married) whether her partner similarly thought about the issues of balancing work with children, she replied:

No, he hasn't. He hasn't really. He's always open to discussion, and he would never shy away from it. It's just he doesn't initiate those types of discussions because we're not there yet, so he doesn't think about it. He's not sure where a year from now is because we're not there yet. And that's different for me because I'm constantly trying to maybe change what I'm doing now to get ready for a year from now. I'm always looking ahead. And he doesn't.

I suspect that the personality differences described by Denise may actually be the product of a long-established system of domesticity in the United States (Williams 2000) rather than innate gender differences in planning preferences and abilities. One pertinent detail that lends support to this argument is that, as a whole, men in my sample had little trouble discussing their future career plans, indicating that they do plan for the future when it comes to their careers. For instance, David (age 31, married), a finance executive, told me that he would likely be pursuing a more entrepreneurial path, saying, "I need to feel like I'm sort of central and important in my work. The best way to do that is just to do it myself; you

know, do whatever I wanna do myself as opposed to signing onto somebody else's payroll." Another man (age 27, engaged) working in tech told me that he hoped for a new position that was a bit more "interesting" and personally satisfying. Reid (age 34, engaged), a senior executive at a health care company, also planned to "go more entrepreneurial" in the near future since "in a couple years I'll get tired of [my current role]. It won't challenge me anymore. I'll need something new." He described the appeal of this path, saying, "I think it would be cool to build something that you can call your own. Also, at that level you can probably do more." At the time of our interview, however, his fiancé (age 26) was looking for a new job in sales, which she felt was a more "family friendly" position than her current office administrative job.

Other men described looking for more seniority in their five- to 10-year trajectories. Steven (age 29, married), a financial analyst, told me that he was hoping to attain more education to move into "more senior-level jobs," like a director position. Rex (age 29, engaged), who was working as an engineer, said he hoped to work his way into either a more senior role or an entrepreneurial role so that he could have more autonomy:

I could do really well in an unstructured kind of thing where it's up to me to get work done when I need to and not when I don't need to. So I like the idea of that . . . when you run your own company you choose who you're going to work with or not work with and you sort of call the shots at the end of the day.

Here, I have extended the concept of mental work (Walzer 1996) to the life stage that precedes parenthood and demonstrated the gender-differentiated ways in which men and women perform (or don't) mental work when anticipating parenthood. Young women's imagined work paths are often obfuscated by anticipations of parenthood, while their male counterparts tend to imagine full-time uninhibited investment in more satisfying and senior-level positions.

The Emotional Consequences of Mental Work

For many women, mental work was not confined to surface-level thought. Instead, it was accompanied by feelings of worry and anxiety. Because men were unlikely to engage in mental work, they were also free from its emotional consequences. One woman (age 26, married) told me it was "challenging to think about" how her work life might change upon

becoming new parents: "I think it's stressful to think about the change of what I'm gonna do. I think [my current place of employment] definitely would allow me to work part-time, but it's more the money aspect." In response to thinking about how her work life could also accommodate new parenthood, one woman (age 26, engaged) told me matter-of-factly, "It freaks me out!" Hannah (age 27, married), a guidance counselor, described it as "stressful to think about."

Many women experienced stress around trying to blend their current aspirations with their timeline for motherhood, feeling they had to plan everything at just the right time in order to achieve both work and family goals. For instance, Allie (age 29, married) was excelling in her career in the IT industry and hoped to attain her MBA to further her career. However, she felt anxiety around the idea of completing the requisite application materials well in advance of parenthood:

I have the pressure of getting into this GMAT class now because I need to be able to start applying soon. Because in all reality I should probably go to business school next fall. Will I be able to go next fall? I'm not sure. But if we're gonna . . . we've talked about the kids thing. And we're, like, "Maybe when you're around 30 and I'm like 32 or 33, let's address it then." Well, I'm gonna be 30 in October so that basically gives me three years to figure out what I wanna do with this program. I mean, you're on a timeline. It has a huge impact on that.

Not a single man in my sample who was considering additional education or career changes mentioned anxiety around coordinating career moves with future parenthood.

Denise (age 27, married), a physician's assistant, described how the topic of paid work and child care preoccupied her thoughts. She had spoken with her mother and girlfriends about what kinds of labor strategies she was considering in the future and illustrates here the emotional struggle of anticipating parenthood in conjunction with gendered expectations of parenthood, which she views as a struggle unique to women:

I feel like just, as a woman, it's really hard because if I choose to work full-time, someone's gonna think negatively on me that I'm not investing at home. But if I'm a stay-at-home, is that necessarily, like, a cop-out? Because I know sometimes opinions go that way. Or if I work part-time, well, then I'm not fully invested in either, so am I really doing anyone a favor by working part-time and being a part-time home role? I'm always talking about it, and ultimately whatever we decide it's gonna be based on what we need for the family.

Denise continued to describe the prominent place the topic occupied in her thoughts lately: "I do talk about it quite a bit. But it's just kind of to talk out loud and process some of my thoughts. Like, 'What do I think about this? What's my attitude toward it? How am I gonna be portrayed?' Because to some extent, that's important to me too."

The Interplay Between Gender, Imagined Work Paths, and The Reproduction of Labor Market Inequality

Despite that respondents had almost never discussed the topic of how their work lives might change upon parenthood with their partners, many were making critical choices based on gendered parenthood expectations. In this section, I show how the anticipated work–family conflict that often accompanies parenthood looms large in the minds of women, influencing their aspirations and career choices. Men, on the other hand, were less likely to be burdened by these anticipations, either mentally or behaviorally.

An Assumed Reordering of Preferences. Cultural expectations about motherhood assume that women should invest extensive amounts of emotion into childrearing (Hays 1996). Even though they were not yet parents, women in my sample seemed attuned to this expectation that their personalities or preferences might (or should) change upon parenthood. For example, one woman (age 27, engaged) was considering going back to school to obtain her PhD, but hesitated to commit to an academic path with children as a near possibility, saying, "With raising a child, who knows how my priorities are gonna change?"

Lacy (age 26, married), a certified public accountant, also longed to go back to school and change careers, but told me, "I would go back to school to do a career change. I actually am really interested in animal science. That's my thing. So I would go back for that, but I think it really depends on kids." Lacy worried specifically that her interests might change after having children:

I just don't know how I'm gonna feel. Right now I still feel like I would want to work. . . . But I don't wanna make a decision to sink all of this money into continuing education if I'm not going to pursue a career with it. I just feel like it would be a waste of money. So I wanna have the kids before I do that to kind of see what my perspective is. If I still feel the same way—which in my head I'm like, "Of course I'm gonna feel the same way!"—but

I don't know. So many people are changed by kids that I just don't wanna make a decision until I have them.

According to Lacy, her husband was not constrained by fatherhood expectations. When asked about his likelihood of attaining more education, she told me, "I wouldn't be surprised if Zach does an executive MBA at night. He is still very interested in doing an MBA." Another respondent (age 34, married), who remained undecided about her work plans, told me, "It all depends on when it [kids] actually happens. Because I've seen people say, 'Oh, I'm gonna go back to work.' And then they get there and they take the whole year off. And then they start to shift everything around just because of that intense experience."

One man (age 27, married) alluded to the culturally assumed reordering of preferences expectation placed on women, but not men, in a rare instance when the couple *had* openly discussed (nontraditional) gender strategies with others: "I don't see her staying at home with kids. But I mean, the thing people tell us is, like, 'Oh, as soon as you have children, that's going to change. She's going to want to stay at home.'" His comments exemplify the external pressure for women to experience a shift in life priorities and preferences upon the birth of a baby.

Anticipating Being the Central Caregiver. Like the gendering of expected changes in *preferences*, expectations of caretaking *responsibilities* were also gendered. One woman (age 27, engaged) struggled to decide which of many possible career paths to pursue, saying that when she has her first child, "I just don't even know what kind of responsibilities I'm gonna have." Frances (age 32, married), a community college counselor, wanted to attain an advanced degree, but worried about how she could balance her educational and professional goals with family caretaking responsibilities:

I feel like I almost have to plan my life around that [future parenthood] a little bit and when that happens. Going to school and being pregnant makes me wonder, "How will that work out?" And then also, everybody says you're exhausted for your first couple of years. I don't do exhausted well.

Frances's husband, on the other hand, planned to go back to school to complete his bachelor's degree and receive several certifications for his work in contracting, but did not mention parenthood responsibilities as barriers to his goals.

Another particularly compelling example comes from the case of Jessica and Steven, a married couple. Jessica (age 30) was a dental hygienist, but felt unsatisfied in her current position and the prospects it offered. Her husband, Steven, was a financial analyst at a large corporate firm. When I asked where she thought her career would go in five to 10 years, Jessica told me:

I've thought a lot about that, actually. Because I feel like I want to diversify and not just work in an office, but maybe go into teaching—maybe getting my master's and pursuing public health or something related to the dental field. I'm not really sure what my timeframe would be, though. Because we, actually, we're thinking about having kids soon. Starting to try within the next year. And I think that would be difficult for me to pursue a master's and have kids at the same time. I'd probably have kids, wait 'til they get a little older, and then go back to school.

Jessica's response is strikingly different from her husband's (age 29) despite that both wanted to pursue a graduate degree in the near future:

Oh, man, five, ten years from now. I guess the career path that I see is that I'd like to go back to school to get my MBA and then kinda use that to launch into more senior-level jobs. I think I have . . . the job that I have right now kinda gives me a good background and good, I guess, foundation to have more senior-level jobs. So five years down the line I'd hope to be in a director-level position, having had an MBA and more experience.

Deferring educational opportunity was not the only way in which women's career trajectories became limited when anticipating family responsibilities. Others shied away from pursuing different work or leadership positions. Betsy (age 30, married), a program director for a mid-sized nonprofit organization, referenced her concerns about blending work and family when discussing her career trajectory, worrying that her original career goals might not be compatible with motherhood:

I go back and forth a lot. For a very long time, I had it in my head that I wanted to be an executive director. Mostly because I wanted to be in charge of everything. But I've been reconsidering that. . . . You know, I think it's a challenge to balance my schedule as it is, but it's a lot more of a load when we have kids. I definitely want to keep working and I'm almost 99, 98 percent positive that includes continuing to work full-time through having kids. But you know . . . there's also, like, this outside chance that, you know, maybe I'll end up consulting for a few years and ending up at this place [being an executive director] later on.

Betsy's 31-year-old husband seemed attuned to her worry and similarly linked it to anticipatory sacrifices in her present career, saying, "I think when she's feeling like she would wanna be a stay-at-home mom for a period of time, it's because she's seeing how she doesn't think she could do all of this [work] plus motherhood at the same time." He, on the other hand, did not mention worrying about this balancing act.

Erin (age 32, engaged), an environmental policy analyst, told me that she was not entirely satisfied in her current position, which left her feeling unchallenged, but she was nevertheless planning to remain in that position rather than seeking something more fulfilling:

It's very low-pressure. A few of the women there have told me, "Oh, it's a great place to have kids." I don't know that it has that great of benefits 'cause I feel like nowhere really does anymore unless you happen to work at some tech start-up or something. . . . But it could be a good reason to hold on to the job if everything else is okay.

In addition to constraining women's preferences for advancement, anticipations of parenthood also led to gendered industry and job choices, offering insight into one cultural mechanism reproducing occupational sex segregation. For instance, Paula (age 26) and her husband were both nearing graduation from law school at the time of their interviews. In discussing their career choices, however, Paula's was to enter the field of dependency, a public sector of legal practice, while her husband's was to enter the more lucrative private practice, free from the expectations and worry described by Paula here:

It's so difficult, because the beginning years of your career are really intense and so it's hard for me to know how that would play out in terms of being able to take time off or even just maternity leave for children. I think that has been something that has a little bit driven my career track, because dependency tends to be much more independent. You can kind of take as many cases as you want. You're essentially your own boss depending on where you work. . . . It tends to have a lot more women and so it's a little bit more friendly towards work, life, and family balance. . . . That has been a driving factor to stay in public practice because I don't see how you can have a family and stay in private practice. I mean, it's possible, but it just makes it a lot harder. So I think that in my head, I've been planning my transition into dependency sort of around that timing as well.

Another woman (age 27, married) told me that she had fully planned on becoming a physician her whole life, saying, "I was just curious about

things. I kind of have that natural drive so I thought that would be a good fit." After meeting her husband in college, however, she began to imagine the family life that they would build together and worried that a doctor's schedule and responsibilities would not be able to accommodate the demands of motherhood. She eventually shifted her career goals to become a physician's assistant, which she believed would allow her to be "flexible later, when we do have a family."

Men's Breadwinner Expectations and Ramping Up. While men were much less likely to alter their career aspirations in anticipation of parenthood, some did; however, these men were similarly affected by traditional breadwinner expectations (Williams 2000). For instance, Charles (age 27, married), husband of Denise, had recently started a contract position in city planning. He told me that he needed to have a "more stable job, for sure" by the time they had kids and that "the pay needs to increase quite a bit in the next five to ten years." Toby (age 31, engaged), a sales associate at a large corporation, said, "Yeah . . . I've put quite a bit of pressure on myself to make sure that I'm earning enough so that when we do get to that point [of having kids], that Tinsley can make whatever decision she wants to around her work." His response highlights not only that the decision to work or stay at home is framed in a rhetoric of "her choice" as other scholars have also found (Stone 2007; Webber and Williams 2008; Williams 2000) but also that his use of the term "pressure" indicates the ties that the system of domesticity has on *his* day-to-day emotions and career choices. Zach (age 31, married), who worked as a business executive and whose wife had recently shifted her career (and salary) in search of a more "mom-friendly company," told me:

I'm kind of at a manager level right now. I'd like to get to director and VP in the next five to ten years. I'm very focused on being successful. It's something that's very important to me. . . . It's something that, if I wanna make my life really good, I wanna make sure my career's really good. Because then I'm a better husband, a better everything, right? It's something that's been ingrained in me as something that's very important.

In the aggregate, these individual-level career choices, which occur early on in couples' relationships, make it more likely that the career outcomes of newly married men and women will diverge even more substantially in the years leading up to parenthood. Zach's wife (age 26) picked up on this divergence in her own marriage and told me, "At some point

it's [her career] not gonna matter. Not because I don't know what I'm doing, but because he works at a place where they definitely compensate." She continued on, describing exactly how their diverging salaries might ultimately affect the labor strategy they adopt upon parenthood, saying, "As he and I become more disparate in how much we make, I think that [choice] will become less of an issue because his salary is gonna ultimately completely eclipse mine at some point."

CONCLUSIONS

Through an analysis of in-depth interviews with 60 childless young adults, I show that anticipations of parenthood are gendered. Irrespective of their age, marital status, and background, women in my sample tended to be more likely to think and worry about combining work with family in the future. Moreover, I find that women tended to downshift certain educational or professional opportunities in conjunction with anticipating parenthood. This occurred when they worried that their preferences and family responsibilities might shift upon the birth of a child, something that men were not affected by. Thus, the study contributes to the extant literature by demonstrating the impact of children on women's work lives before children are actually born.

Additionally, the study builds in the voices of men, which are more often than not absent from the literature on parenthood and career choices (for notable exceptions, see Cowan and Cowan 1992; Gerson 2010; Walzer 1996). Doing so makes clear that parenthood is less influential in men's minds and present-day career choices than it is for women. This article also contributes to current theoretical understandings of how gendered career aspirations emerge and shift through the life course by showing that it is not only gender status and stereotypes that push women into lower-rewarded educational and professional paths, as previous research has found (Cheryan et al. 2009; Correll 2004; Lips 2000, 2007), but also anticipation of motherhood and family responsibilities that constrains preferences even before individuals actually enter into parenthood.

The study diverges in important ways from earlier scholarship as well. For instance, I have argued here that at least some, if not all, of the reasons that young women are more likely to think about, worry about, and plan for future parenthood is because of socially constructed gender expectations surrounding parenthood. It is possible, however, that some of the gendered behavior described here could also be attributed to interactional

dynamics within the couple. In other words, women worry and prepare for parenthood because their partners do not (see Walzer 1996, 223-24). Given that my respondents had not yet had children and almost none had explicitly talked to their partners about their work–family lives upon parenthood, couple-level dynamics appear to be a smaller factor in my study.

My work also complements scholarship on how aspirations shift in response to life experiences. In her intersectional study of women's attitudes toward continual versus intermittent work, Damaske (2011) finds that middle-class women (not necessarily mothers) reported being unlikely to anticipate occasional workforce participation when they were first entering the workforce. Research by Gerson (2010) and Pedulla and Thébaud (2013) also found that unmarried, childless women are more likely to prefer to fall back on a work–family strategy of financial autonomy, as opposed to a neotraditional arrangement, if their "Plan A" egalitarian strategy proved impossible. Compared to these studies, women in my sample were more likely to express uncertainty about the continuity of their labor force participation upon parenthood, many considering a multitude of options including more neotraditional arrangements. I suspect that these differences may be because of the different points in the life course at which respondents were asked about their expectations. For instance, participants in the aforementioned studies were either in (or recalling) their late teens and early twenties, most of whom were presumably single at that time. Thus, the difference in aspirations may be the result of exposure to the gendered institution of marriage, which can shift the behavior and ideologies of even committed egalitarians (Risman 1998; Vespa 2009).

For many in my sample, advanced education and career shifts would have offered the possibility to move into more satisfying opportunities, which is negatively correlated with intentions to switch jobs or quit (Bockerman and Ilmakunnas 2009). This means that the effects of *not* pursuing potentially more fulfilling occupational possibilities due to gendered anticipations of parenthood may be one of the primary ways through which new mothers' careers (and tenure and income trajectories) become limited before the real time and financial constraints of parenthood have set in.

It is important to note that seven of the 30 couples in my sample diverged substantially from the patterns reported earlier, offering preliminary insight into the conditions surrounding the process described here. One of these couples was counter-conventional by fully anticipating that the husband would assume the primary caretaker role upon parenthood. This couple had similarly begun the process of recalibrating their present career aspirations in accordance with this expectation, with her ramping up and him moving into a more flexible work arrangement. The other six

couples were also unique in two distinct ways, indicating two potential conditions under which these patterns occur. Among the three couples that were uncertain about their likelihood of becoming parents, not a single one followed the patterns described here. We can speculate, then, that formed parenthood aspirations are a condition under which gendered anticipations of parenthood are likely to occur. Another condition is couples' financial resources. While all could be, at minimum, considered middle-class, those at the very bottom end of the household income distribution did not follow the patterns described here. They cited less uncertainty, saying instead that each partner needed to maximize his or her income in order to survive financially.

One limitation to the study is that it is focused on mostly class-privileged heterosexual couples. This precludes me from speaking to how this process might work among a group of couples with lower levels of human and economic capital or couples in same-sex partnerships. Further, because of the small-scale nature of this and any in-depth study based on a nonprobability sample, the findings cannot be interpreted as generalizable to the broader population. The sample size also precludes me from analyzing how factors like age, length of time together, and marital status affect the process. My analysis suggests gender expectations associated with marriage and parenthood supersede variation in these characteristics, perhaps because respondents are all in a similar life stage, facing similar anticipations, constraints, and expectations; however, further research should be conducted in order to address these lingering questions.

Future research might also address whether other inequalities, beyond the labor market, might ensue from the gendered mental and anticipatory work described here. For example, it is likely that women who are dubbed "planners" in their current relationships will also be those expected to worry about children (and other family needs) in the future. Thus, the gendered mental work described here may be a precursor to the gendered baby worry described by Walzer (1996) as well as the inequalities in care work that emerge in new parenthood. Further, it is plausible that the planning work done by many women may put a strain on women's mental and emotional wellbeing as well as the couple's relationship stability in the future if women partners feel alone in planning couples' future family lives. Future scholarship might explore whether this gender difference, over time, affects the mental health experiences of young women and men and, in turn, couples' relationship satisfaction as they move from single partnership to parenthood.

As this study shows, anticipations of having children affect women's (but not men's) career aspirations and behavior prior to, and often well before, the point when a couple has children. Thus the effect of children

on women's careers is even greater than what previous research has shown. Because anticipated parenthood differentially affects how men and women plan their careers, men and women are likely, in the aggregate, to end up in substantially different occupational positions, thereby perpetuating gender inequality in the workplace and at home. To reduce this effect requires making work and family more compatible so that the conflict between the two does not loom so large in women's minds as they make early career choices. Doing so would benefit parents as well as the growing number of young women and men who aspire to have egalitarian work–family arrangements in their future family lives.

NOTES

1. A male research assistant, who was carefully trained in the interview protocol procedure by the author, conducted 20 percent ($n = 6$) of the interviews with men. Themes were consistent across these interviews, suggesting that my presence as a female researcher did not shape the male interviewees' responses in any relevant ways.

2. For more information about the study, please contact the author.

3. The figures presented in this table come from data that were collected in an online survey. Because I wanted to ensure that the survey, which included several attitudinal questions, did not skew interview responses, a subset of the respondents took the survey before the interview and the rest after the interview.

4. Respondents' names and some identifying characteristics have been changed to protect confidentiality.

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